



WHAT HIRING MANAGERS NOTICE FIRST

Practical questions, readiness
scorecard, and the complete
104-quote dataset

COMPANION WORKBOOK





HOW TO USE THIS WORKBOOK

This workbook is the companion to Clarivue's research report, 'What Hiring Managers Notice First.' The main report identifies six patterns that determine interview outcomes. This workbook gives you tools to act on them.

Inside you'll find three things:

01 First, a set of practical questions for each of the six themes. These are designed for advisors, coaches, and career services staff to use in mock interviews, coaching sessions, or candidate prep. They surface specific readiness signals, not general interview performance.

02 Second, a printable readiness scorecard. Use it during mock interviews to rate candidates across all six themes. It gives advisors a structured way to see where each person is strong and where they need work.

03 Third, the other responses we received that formed dataset we used for the report research. The main report features 50 curated quotes. This workbook includes all other responses so you have the full picture.

ADVISOR'S QUESTION BANK

These questions are pulled from the patterns hiring managers described. Use them in mock interviews, one-on-one coaching, or group prep sessions. They're designed to surface the specific signals that real interviewers are screening for.

THEME 1

Ownership

These questions test whether a candidate can be honest about their mistakes and take responsibility for outcomes.

- ? Tell me about a time you made a decision at work that didn't go the way you expected. What happened, and what did you do about it?
- ? What's a project or task you were involved in that didn't succeed? What was your specific role in why it didn't work?
- ? If I called your last supervisor right now and asked them about your biggest area for growth, what would they say?
- ? Describe a time you had to admit to a coworker or a supervisor that you were wrong about something. How did you handle it?
- ? When things go wrong on a team, how do you usually figure out what happened? Walk me through your process.
- ? What's something you used to believe about your work that you've since changed your mind about? What made you reconsider?



What you're listening for:

Specificity over vagueness. 'I' statements over 'we' deflections. The ability to name a concrete mistake without blaming someone else. Evidence of reflection: what they learned, what they'd change.

THEME 2

Listening first

These questions test whether a candidate understands before they answer, or performs before they think.

- ❓ We've got a client who's unhappy with the service they received. How would you handle it? (Deliberately vague. See if they ask for more information before answering.)
- ❓ Walk me through how you'd approach your first week in this role. (Note whether they ask about priorities, team structure, or existing processes before describing their plan.)
- ❓ A coworker comes to you with a problem they can't figure out. What do you do first?
- ❓ I'm going to describe a situation and I want you to tell me what you'd do. But first, tell me what else you'd need to know before you could give me a real answer. (Then describe a scenario with missing details.)
- ❓ What questions would you ask before starting a new project at a job?
- ❓ Tell me about a time you realized mid-task that you'd misunderstood what was being asked. What happened?



What you're listening for:

Clarifying questions before answers. The instinct to probe for context. The ability to say 'I don't have enough information to answer that yet.' If they launch straight into solutions for a vague scenario, that's the signal.

THEME 3

Composure under pressure

These questions test how a candidate handles uncertainty, silence, and not knowing.

- ❓ Tell me about something in your field that you don't fully understand yet. How do you deal with that gap?
- ❓ I'm going to ask you a question you might not know the answer to. That's the point. [Then ask a domain-specific question slightly outside their stated experience.]
- ❓ What would you do if your supervisor gave you feedback you thought was wrong?
- ❓ Have you ever been in a situation where you had to make a decision without all the information? What happened?
- ❓ [After they answer a question, pause for 5–7 seconds before responding. Observe what they do in the silence. Do they sit comfortably, or do they start backtracking and revising?]
- ❓ Tell me about a time you were put on the spot in front of other people. How did you handle it?



What you're listening for:

Comfort with not knowing. The ability to say 'I'm not sure, but here's how I'd think about it.' Whether they hold their ground or fold under gentle pushback. How they handle silence: do they sit in it, or rush to fill it?

THEME 4

Preparation

These questions test whether a candidate cared enough to do the work before they showed up.

- ❓ What do you know about us and why did you apply here specifically?
- ❓ What's one thing about our organization that stood out to you when you were researching us?
- ❓ If you were going to explain what we do to a friend who's never heard of us, what would you say?
- ❓ What questions do you have for us about the role or the team? (Ask this early, not at the end. Prepared candidates have questions throughout, not just when prompted.)
- ❓ What did you do to get ready for this conversation today?
- ❓ Is there anything about this role that concerns you or that you're unsure about?



What you're listening for:

Specific references to the organization, not generic flattery. Questions that show genuine curiosity about the work, not just the logistics. Whether they ask about schedule and pay only, or whether they ask about the team, the clients, or the challenges.

THEME 5

Communication clarity

These questions test whether a candidate can explain their thinking simply and clearly.

- ? Explain something you're really good at to me as if I know nothing about your field.
- ? Walk me through a decision you made recently at work. Start with the problem and end with what happened.
- ? If you had to explain your last role to a 10-year-old, what would you say?
- ? Tell me about a time you had to simplify something complicated for someone. How did you approach it?
- ? What does good work look like in your field? Be specific.
- ? Describe a time you and a coworker saw the same situation differently. How did you work it out?



What you're listening for:

Plain language over jargon. Structured answers (situation, action, result) over rambling. The ability to adjust their language based on who they're talking to. Whether they can describe the 'why' behind a decision, not just the 'what.'

THEME 6

Presence and awareness

These are less about specific questions and more about what to observe during the full interaction.

- ❓ [Observe: How did they enter the room or join the call? Did they acknowledge anyone else present?]
- ❓ [Observe: Do they match their energy and tone to the setting, or are they on autopilot?]
- ❓ [Observe: When you shift topics or tone mid-conversation, do they adjust or keep barreling forward?]
- ❓ Tell me about a time you had to adjust your approach because you read the room and realized something wasn't landing.
- ❓ How do you usually prepare for meeting someone new in a professional context?
- ❓ [Observe: How do they treat your support staff, receptionist, or anyone else they interacted with before the interview started?]



What you're listening for:

Observation without prompting. Whether they treat the interview as a live two-way conversation or a rehearsed performance. Respect for the space, the people, and the small logistics. Adaptability when you shift gears.

INTERVIEW READINESS SCORECARD

Use this during mock interviews or coaching sessions. Rate the candidate 1–5 on each theme based on the signals described in the question bank. A score of 3 means ‘acceptable.’ Below 3 means the candidate needs targeted coaching on that theme before a real interview.

Candidate name: _____ Date: _____ Advisor: _____

01. Ownership

What To Look For

Takes responsibility.
Names specific mistakes.
Reflects on what they learned.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

02. Listening

What To Look For

Asks before answering.
Probes for context. Doesn't jump to solutions.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

03. Composure

What To Look For

Handles silence and uncertainty. Doesn't bluff or fold under pushback.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

04. Preparation

What To Look For

Researched the role/company. Asks genuine questions. Curious about the work.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

05. Communication

What To Look For

Explains clearly. Uses plain language. Structures their thinking.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

06. Presence

What To Look For

Reads the room. Adapts. Acknowledges people. Matches energy to setting.

SCORE ○○○○○ /5

Scoring guide: 1 = significant gap (coaching urgently needed), 2 = below expectations (needs practice), 3 = acceptable (can hold their own), 4 = strong (confident and natural), 5 = exceptional (would impress most interviewers).

Recommendation threshold: candidates scoring below 18/30 overall or below 3 on any single theme should receive targeted coaching before being referred to employers.

Six Signals that Decide Interviews Before Resumes Do.

01

Ownership

Can they be honest about themselves?

Knowing if the candidate can talk about being wrong without flinching.

- ⊕ Names a specific mistake; uses "I" naturally; describes what they learned.
- ⊖ Sanitized non-answers; "we" deflections; blames manager, tools, or team.



"Tell me about a project that didn't succeed. What was your specific role in why it didn't work?"

02

Listening first

Do they understand before they answer?

Strong candidates diagnose before they prescribe.

- ⊕ Pauses; asks clarifying questions; frames assumptions before answering.
- ⊖ Answers the question they wished you'd asked; never asks one of their own.



"We've got a client who's unhappy with the service. How would you handle it?"

03

Composure

What happens when things get uncomfortable?

How candidates behave when they don't have an answer.

- ⊕ Sits with silence; names the gap; stays steady under pushback.
- ⊖ Bluffs through; folds immediately; fills the silence anxiously.



After their answer, pause for 5-7 seconds. Watch what they do.

04

Preparation

Did they do the work before they showed up?

The gap between "showed up" and "showed up prepared".

- ⊕ Specific reference to the organization; curious about the actual work.
- ⊖ Knows nothing about the role; only asks about schedule and pay.



"What do you know about us, and why did you apply here specifically?"

05

Communication

Can they explain their thinking clearly?

Whether you can break it down in a way that makes sense to someone else.

- ⊕ Plain language; clear arc; explains the "why," not just the "what".
- ⊖ Hides behind buzzwords; rambles, circles back, loses the thread.



"Walk me through a recent decision. Start with the problem, end with what happened."

06

Presence

Do they read the room?

The interview isn't a separate performance; it's a live demo.

- ⊕ Observant entry; acknowledges everyone; adapts as the conversation shifts.
- ⊖ Rehearsed monologue on autopilot; ignores cues; dismisses support staff.



Watch the entry. Watch how they treat your front desk.

OTHER INTERESTING QUOTES WE RECEIVED

The main report features the 50 strongest quotes. Below are the remaining responses, organized by theme. Many of these contain excellent industry-specific insights that may be particularly relevant for programs serving specific sectors.

► Ownership (remaining quotes)



“The most significant indicator of whether an applicant is suitable for hire is how they present their previous challenges, not on their resume.

You want to see a potential employee taking professional responsibility for his/her job, not just technical skills.”

— Amit Agrawal, Founder & COO, [Developers.dev](#)



“I notice when they really struggle with hypothetical questions about the role.

When a candidate doesn't really know how to answer these questions, to me that says that they may not be quite ready for responsibilities of the role.”

— Steve Schwab, CEO, Casago



“Constant hedging or self-doubt is a big red flag. In an interview, it reads very differently.

What I see is someone who isn't fully confident in their own abilities. If anything, I'd rather see someone err on the side of confident than overly reserved.”

— Ben Lamarche, General Manager, Lock Search Group



“The first signal is a lack of clarity in how they communicate their own decisions.

Readiness is less about polish and more about self-awareness and ownership.”

— Aditya Nagpal, Founder & CEO, Wisemonk

▶ Listening first (remaining quotes)



“I’m always on the lookout for that blank stare younger and less qualified candidates get when I throw them a question they weren’t expecting.

Great candidates can think on their feet and come up with a convincing answer, or gracefully admit they don’t know.”

— Jonathan Palley, CEO, QR Codes Unlimited



“In hospitality and corporate housing, the tell I always watch for is how someone handles an unexpected client problem in the room.

The candidates who are ready start solving before they finish hearing the problem. The other thing I notice is whether someone listens to understand or listens to respond.”

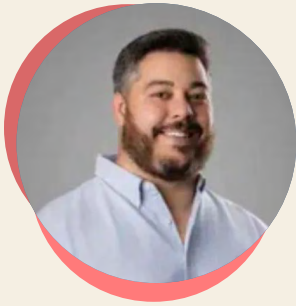
— Nick Morrar, Operations, Ryan Corporate Housing



“Zero proactive input on traveler pain points during scenario discussions.

When we role-play a stranded employee, ready candidates jump in with duty-of-care fixes; others stay silent.”

— Jay Ellenby, President, Safe Harbors



“I run a revenue-focused marketing agency for contractors.

The first tell is they talk in buzzwords and opinions, but can’t define what ‘good’ looks like in measurable terms. If they can’t explain their feedback loop, they’re not ready to own results.”

— Chris McVey, Founder, On Deck Marketing

► **Composure (remaining quotes)**



“The first thing I notice is whether a candidate can clearly explain their decision-making process.

If someone cannot explain how they approached a problem, it usually signals a lack of real experience.”

— Assaf Sternberg, Founder & CEO, Tiroflx



“The first thing I notice is a lack of ‘systemic thinking’ — when a candidate views their role as a series of manual, isolated actions rather than a repeatable process.

A candidate who focuses only on the manual effort and ignores the leverage of automation will eventually become a bottleneck.”

— Renzo Proano, Team Principal, Berelvant AI



“The moment a candidate can’t explain why they did something, only what they did, I know they’re not ready.

In regulated environments, the ‘why’ is everything. Anyone can follow a protocol. Far fewer can defend the reasoning behind it.”

— Stephen Ferrell, Chief Product Officer, Valkit.ai



“My background in competitive intelligence taught me that systems thinking is useless without a foundation of human connection.

The first red flag is a candidate’s inability to introduce themselves beyond their professional title.”

— Jillyn Dillon, Founder & CSO, Technology Aloha

► Preparation (remaining quotes)



“We specialize in high-stakes installations where following manufacturer-certified standards is non-negotiable.

A candidate who glosses over the specific ‘how’ of their past work usually lacks the integrity needed for our final walk-through inspections.”

— Matt Lopez, Owner, Matt’s Exteriors



“A candidate who doesn’t show the promptness and thoroughness we’re known for before the interview even starts likely won’t meet our standards.

I look for whether they’ve researched our specific difference.”

— Sean Baber, Co-Owner, Baber Enterprises Inc.



“The biggest red flag is a lack of research into a client’s specific environment.

If a candidate hasn’t looked at the local rankings before our call, they aren’t ready to handle our system.”

— Josh Preece, Owner, J&A Digital Solutions



“Having served as a Navy Quality Assurance Inspector, I prioritize a candidate’s respect for protocol over their technical stats.

Preparation is the ultimate indicator of accountability.”

— Ernie Bussell, CEO, Your Home Solar

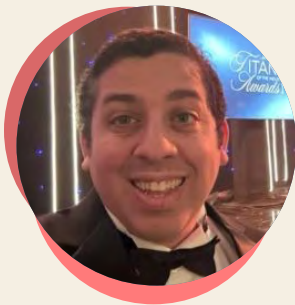
► Communication (remaining quotes)



“Usually when we are hiring for a role, in addition to qualifications and hard skills, we are also looking for some specific soft skills.

If a candidate doesn’t appear to be on par with the soft skills we are looking for, that often indicates that they aren’t ready.”

— Rassan Grant, Founder, Norstone



“A reliance on ‘geek speak’ signals they cannot translate complex risks into the plain English our clients need to make decisions.

I also look for a lack of professional polish, specifically regarding punctuality and attire.”

— Paul Nebb, CEO, Titan Technologies



“Using ‘weak’ words like ‘just,’ ‘actually,’ or ‘I think’ tells me they aren’t ready to own their results.

If a candidate hasn’t researched our competitors or the vibe of our brand before the meeting, they haven’t put in the hard work.”

— Trav Lubinsky, Founder, Trav Brand



“In web design, the giveaway is how they handle constraints: performance, SEO, and real content.

If they don't ask about CMS structure, loading speed, or redirects, they're not thinking like someone who ships.”

— Divyansh Agarwal, Founder, Webyansh

▶ Presence (remaining quotes)



“Thirty years of hiring people taught me to watch how someone treats the space around them the moment they walk in.

Someone who can't manage a chair in an interview won't manage a job site.”

— Eric Osburn, Owner, Osburn Services



“If a candidate mindlessly interacts with touchpoints without observing the space, they haven't connected with our mission.

If you aren't curious about the mechanics of the world you're sitting in, you likely won't have the vision to help us scale.”

— Debra Vanderhoff, Founder, MicroLumix



“The moment someone sits down and immediately starts performing, rattling off accomplishments before I’ve asked anything, I know they’re not listening.

Leadership isn’t about broadcasting, it’s about reading the room.”

— Walt Carter, President, THG Advisors



“How a candidate carries themselves the moment they walk in, before they say a single word.

The candidates who aren’t ready treat the interview like something happening to them instead of an opportunity they’re running.”

— Marlene Brooks, Owner, Elite Dymond Designs Beauty School



“The first red flag is low energy, like slouching or fidgeting during a casual yard walk-through chat.

Ready hires bounce with energy, eyeing our equipment and asking about the work from day one.”

— Andrew Day, Owner, Advanced Quality Lawn



“I’ve hired drivers for everything from school camps to senior tours.

The first red flag is zero enthusiasm for passengers’ stories. That disconnect kills it; our edge is that driver passion turning transport into experiences.”

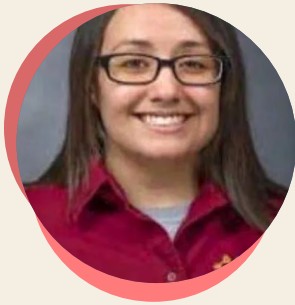
— Cam Storey, Owner, Brisbane 360



“The moment someone sits down and immediately goes into ‘performance mode,’ overly rehearsed, almost robotic, I know they’re not ready.

They’re managing impressions instead of having a real conversation.”

— Jeff Nuziard, CEO, Sexual Wellness Centers of America



“It’s how they treat the space they walk into. A slight wrinkle of the nose at the cleaning equipment, or completely ignoring the person at the front desk.

The candidates who are actually ready treat every environment like it matters.”

— Ashley Cordova, Vice President, Zia Building Maintenance



WHAT'S NEXT

The questions in this workbook are powerful on their own. But they're even more effective when they're part of a structured system that tracks readiness across your entire caseload.

That's what Clarivue's Mock Interview Engine does. It runs simulations calibrated to real roles, scores candidates on the exact signals in this report, and gives advisors a readiness profile for every learner, so coaching is targeted, not guesswork.

Want to see what the gap between training and jobs is costing your program?

Run your numbers at clarivue.io/hidden-cost

Want to talk to us?



AI infrastructure for workforce and
employment training programs

clarivue.io

© 2026 SkillConnect Technologies Ltd. All rights reserved.